Thale Khiao Reef Foundation Launches Starfish Sweep 2026 to Contain Crown-of-Thorns Outbreak off Koh Phangan

Thale Khiao Reef Foundation · Press release Ref. TKRF-PR-2026-09 · For immediate release · 21 September 2026

THONG SALA, KOH PHANGAN, 21 September 2026 — The Thale Khiao Reef Foundation today announced Starfish Sweep 2026, a four-month campaign with local dive operators to remove crown-of-thorns starfish from reefs around Koh Phangan and the Sail Rock pinnacle. The campaign runs from 1 October 2026 to 31 January 2027 and follows a Foundation survey that found outbreak-level numbers of the coral-eating starfish at two of the three monitored sites.

1. What the September survey found

Foundation survey teams counted starfish along fixed transects at three sites between 2 and 6 September 2026. The Foundation treats a reef as being in outbreak when it holds more than 15 adult starfish per hectare, the level at which the starfish eat coral faster than it can regrow.

- Sail Rock: 38 starfish per hectare, the highest count recorded at the site since monitoring began in 2019. Live hard coral cover on the eastern wall fell from 46 % in March 2026 to 31 % in September.
- Mae Haad and the Koh Ma channel: 22 starfish per hectare, up from 11 per hectare at the end of the 2025–26 pilot.
- Chalok Baan Kao bay: 9 starfish per hectare, below the outbreak level. This site will be monitored but not swept.

Feeding scars, which show as fresh white patches of dead coral, were seen on about one table coral in four at Sail Rock. Divers also reported clusters of juvenile starfish shorter than 15 cm, which suggests that a second wave of adults could appear in 2027 if nothing is done.

"Crown-of-thorns starfish are a natural part of the reef, but at these numbers they can strip a coral wall in a single season," said Dr. Kanittha Sombatwong, Executive Director of the Thale Khiao Reef Foundation. "The pilot at Mae Haad showed that trained local divers can bring numbers down quickly. This year we are paying operators more, and we are going out to Sail Rock, where the damage is worst."

2. Results of the 2025–26 pilot

The Foundation ran a smaller pilot at Mae Haad only, from 12 November 2025 to 28 February 2026, with four dive operators and its own staff divers. Over 61 diving days the pilot removed 3,140 starfish, and the density at Mae Haad fell from 41 to 11 starfish per hectare. No diver was injured by a starfish spine during the pilot, although two divers needed treatment for minor jellyfish stings. The pilot cost 512,000 baht, which was paid for entirely by the Foundation's own reserves.

Starfish Sweep 2026 sets a combined removal target of 9,000 starfish across Sail Rock and Mae Haad, with the aim of bringing both sites below 10 starfish per hectare by the end of January 2027.

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3. Who can take part

Any dive operator based on Koh Phangan or Koh Samui may join, provided it has a valid boat and business licence and registers with the Foundation before its first sweep dive. Registration opens on 23 September 2026 and closes on 15 October 2026. Operators who join after the campaign has started may begin sweeping on the Monday after their registration is confirmed.

Each diver who culls starfish must meet all of the following conditions:

- hold an advanced open water certification or higher, from any recognised training agency;
- have at least 30 logged dives, of which at least 10 were made in the Gulf of Thailand;
- complete the Foundation's three-hour Starfish Sweep training session, which covers species identification, the injection method, spine safety and data recording.

Training sessions are held in Training Room 2 of the Foundation's office on Thong Sala Pier Road, starting at 09:00 on 28 September, 5 October and 12 October 2026. Each session takes up to 16 divers. Divers who completed the pilot training in 2025 must attend a one-hour refresher instead, because the injection method has changed (see section 4). Training is free of charge, and operators may send as many divers as they wish.

4. How the starfish are removed

Divers remove the starfish in place, using a single injection from the Foundation's sealed injection kit. The kit and the dose are set out in the Foundation's field protocol TK-COTS-3, which replaces the TK-COTS-2 protocol used in the pilot. Under the old protocol each starfish received two injections; under TK-COTS-3 one injection is enough, which roughly doubles the number of starfish a diver can treat on one tank. Starfish are not brought to the surface, because handling them on the boat caused most of the spine injuries recorded by other programmes.

Kits are issued to registered operators free of charge from the Foundation office and must be returned, used or unused, by 7 February 2027. Each kit treats about 120 starfish. Operators who lose a kit are charged 2,500 baht for its replacement.

Dive rules during the sweep

- Sweep dives must be made in buddy pairs. Only one diver of each pair injects; the other records and watches for hazards.
- No culling deeper than 18 metres, even if the diver is certified to go deeper.
- No sweep dive may start if underwater visibility is less than 5 metres or if the Foundation has posted a strong-current warning for the site.
- At Sail Rock, divers must not enter the vertical swim-through known as the Chimney during a sweep dive. Starfish found there are reported for removal by Foundation staff.
- Inside the roped coral nursery at Mae Haad, only Foundation staff divers may cull starfish. Operator divers who see a starfish inside the nursery ropes report its position in the app and leave it in place.

Note. Every sweep dive must be logged in the ReefTally app within 24 hours of surfacing, with the site, the GPS mark, the maximum depth, the number of starfish treated and at least one photo per ten starfish. Dives logged after 24 hours are recorded for science but are not paid.

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5. Payments to dive operators

The Foundation pays operators, not individual divers, for each starfish treated and logged correctly. For Starfish Sweep 2026 the rates are:

- Mae Haad: 45 baht per starfish. The pilot rate was 30 baht.
- Sail Rock: 60 baht per starfish, to reflect the longer boat trip and stronger currents.
- Fuel support for Sail Rock: 1,200 baht per day on which the operator makes at least one sweep dive at Sail Rock. There is no fuel support for Mae Haad.

Payments are capped at 400 starfish per operator per calendar week (Monday to Sunday), across both sites together. Starfish treated above the cap are still welcome and still counted toward the campaign target, but they are not paid. The Foundation pays by bank transfer on or before the 10th day of the month after the dives, based on the ReefTally records. Queries about a payment must be sent within 30 days of the transfer date.

An operator that does not log a dive in ReefTally for 21 days in a row is treated as inactive. It must return its kits, but it may rejoin by contacting the field coordinator.

6. Funding and partners

The campaign has a total budget of 2.4 million baht. Of this, 1.5 million baht comes from a grant by the Nok Thale Coastal Trust, 600,000 baht from the Koh Phangan Dive Operators' Circle through a voluntary 20-baht reef levy that member shops add to each guest dive, and the remaining 300,000 baht from the Foundation's reserves. The budget covers operator payments, fuel support, injection kits, training and two follow-up surveys, which are planned for 8–12 December 2026 and 9–13 February 2027.

"Our members see the damage on every dive at Sail Rock," said Chanchai Meesuk, Chair of the Koh Phangan Dive Operators' Circle. "Guests have been happy to pay the levy once we explain where the money goes."

Survey results will be published on the Foundation's website within three weeks of each survey. Members of the public who see crown-of-thorns starfish at other sites around Koh Phangan, Koh Tao or Koh Samui are asked to send a photo and location to the Foundation, but not to touch or try to remove the starfish themselves.

Notes for editors

The Thale Khiao Reef Foundation is a non-profit marine conservation organisation founded in 2014 and based in Thong Sala, Koh Phangan. It runs reef monitoring at nine sites in the western Gulf of Thailand, a coral nursery at Mae Haad and school education visits. Field operations for Starfish Sweep 2026 are led by Ratchada Inthawong, Field Coordinator, who handles operator registration, kit issue and payment queries.

Media contact: Ploynapat Srisuk, Communications Officer, Thale Khiao Reef Foundation, telephone 077 349 218, email press@thalekhiao-reef.example. Photographs and underwater video from the September survey are available on request. Interviews with Dr. Kanittha Sombatwong can be arranged on weekdays between 10:00 and 16:00.

— Ends —

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